Protected areas

National parks, nature reserves, wilderness areas, and sites of special scientific interest (SSSIs) are all types of protected habitats. Within these areas, interference with the natural environment is prohibited or limited by some kind of legal framework. They must cover a specified expanse of land or sea, but can vary greatly in size and in the level of protection given. Just over 15 percent of Earth's terrestrial and freshwater areas are protected, but only 8.4 percent of the oceans and coastal areas. Given the effort to protect 30 percent of Earth by 2030, progress must accelerate.

Marae Moana, one of the largest protected areas, covers 772,000 sq miles (2 million sq km) in the Pacific Ocean. It is home to sea turtles, at least 136 species of corals, and 21 whales and dolphins. One of the biggest land reserves is the Northeast Greenland National Park, covering almost 386,000 sq miles (1 million sq km) of ice sheet and tundra.